Philosophy · Metaphysics of God · Arguments for the existence of God

# The Cosmological Argument

Consolidation workbook to accompany the slideshow: the Kalam, Aquinas, Leibniz and the objections from Hume and Russell

Use this workbook alongside the slides. Each part follows the order of the slideshow. Work through it in short bursts: every task is self-contained, so if you miss a lesson you can pick up at the next Part without losing your place.

IN THIS WORKBOOK


1. Technical terminology
2. Origins: Aristotle, Anselm and the mediaeval axioms
3. The Kalam argument
4. Aquinas: sustaining causes and the argument from motion
5. Aquinas' Third Way
6. Leibniz's argument from contingency
7. The objections: Hume and Russell
8. Twelve-mark practice


**How to use the symbols**

✎ Short question — a word, phrase or one sentence.

✎✎ Medium question — two to four sentences. Use 'because' and 'therefore' to show the logic.

▦ Table — fill in every empty cell. Keep each cell brief: notes, not essays.

◇ Diagram — map the argument in the boxes, then explain it in prose underneath.

## Part 01 Technical terminology

Key idea The cosmological argument depends on five technical terms. If you can define and illustrate each one, every later Part becomes easier.

### Table: key terms ▦

| Term | Definition in your own words | An example of your own |
|---|---|---|
| Necessary | | |

| Term | Definition in your own words | An example of your own |
|---|---|---|
| Contingent | | |
| Sufficient reason | | |
| Temporal cause | | |
| Sustaining cause | | |

## Short questions ✎

**1.1** Is your own existence necessary or contingent? Give a reason.

**1.2** Is '2 + 2 = 4' necessary or contingent? Give a reason.

# Part 02 Origins and axioms

> *'That there exists a nature, through which everything that exists exists, which exists through itself, and which is, of all things that exist, supreme.'*
>
> — Anselm of Canterbury, Monologion (as quoted on slide 4)

## Short questions ✎

**2.1** Who first understood there to be a 'first mover' of all things?

**2.2** Why did Aristotle's view differ from later Christian versions of the argument? (Hint: how did he understand the world?)

2.3 In Anselm's words, what kind of being does the argument want to prove exists?

### Table: the mediaeval axioms ▦

Slide 5 lists the basic axioms that mediaeval thinkers accepted. Rewrite each one simply, then say which later argument depends on it.

| Axiom | In your own words | Which argument relies on it? |
|---|---|---|
| 'Nothing exists through nothing.' | | |
| Everything that exists has a cause of its existence. | | |
| An infinite regress of causes is not possible. | | |

## Part 03 The Kalam argument

### Diagram: map the Kalam argument ◇

Write each premise from slide 6 in the boxes, then complete the conclusion.

| P1 Everything that exists... | P2 The world... |
|---|---|

▼

| C Therefore... |
|---|

3.1 Which schools developed the Kalam argument, and when?

3.2 Which of the two premises would a critic most likely attack? Explain why.

## Part 04 Aquinas: the argument from motion

Key idea Aquinas is interested in sustaining causes, not temporal ones. A sustaining cause exists at the same time as its effect; remove the cause and you remove the effect.

### Table: temporal vs sustaining causes

| | Temporal cause | Sustaining cause |
|---|---|---|
| Definition (slide 7) | | |
| Can the effect continue if the cause stops? | | |
| An example of your own | | |

4.1 Explain the example of iron made red-hot by fire (slide 9). Why is this a sustaining cause?

## Diagram: Aquinas' argument from motion ◇

Slide 8 sets out the argument in nine steps. Group them into the four stages below.

| Stage 1: what we observe (step 1) | Stage 2: nothing sustains itself; causes form a chain (steps 2–4) |
|---|---|

▼

| Stage 3: the problem of infinite regress (steps 5–6) |
|---|

▼

| Stage 4: conclusion (steps 7–9) |
|---|

**4.2** Now explain the diagram in continuous prose. Make clear why an infinite regress would mean nothing was sustained now.

> *'It follows that all things that are diversified by their diverse sharing in existence, so that some are fuller beings than others, are caused by one first being which simply is in the fullest sense of the word.'*
> — Aquinas (as quoted on slide 10)

**4.3** What does Aquinas mean by things 'sharing in existence'? Who is the being that 'simply is'?

Part 05

# Aquinas' Third Way

## Diagram: rebuild the Third Way ◇

Fill each box with the step from slide 15 in your own words. The argument works like a reductio: it imagines 'nothing' and shows why that cannot be.

| 1 Things exist contingently | 2 If something can not-exist… |
|---|---|

▼

| 3 If everything were contingent… |
|---|

▼

| 4 From nothing… | 5 But things do exist, so… |
|---|---|

▼

| 6–7 Therefore… |
|---|

**5.1** Explain how step 4 ('from nothing, nothing can come into existence') does the key work in the argument.

**5.2** Which step do you think is the weakest? Explain why.

## Table: compare Aquinas' two arguments ▦

| | Argument from motion | Third Way |
|---|---|---|
| Starting observation | | |
| Key concept | | |
| Why there cannot be an infinite chain / 'nothing' | | |
| What God is shown to be | | |

# Part 06 Leibniz: argument from contingency

> *'For neither in any one single thing, nor in the whole aggregate and series of things, can there be found the sufficient reason for existence...And so however far back to earlier states, you will never find in those states a full reason why there should be any world rather than none, and why it should be such as it is.'*
>
> — Leibniz (as quoted on slide 16)

## Short questions ✎

**6.1** What is a 'sufficient reason'?

**6.2** According to the quotation, why can we never find the sufficient reason for the world by going 'back to earlier states'?

## Table: truths of reason and truths of fact ▦

| | Truths of reason | Truths of fact |
|---|---|---|
| **Necessary or contingent?** | | |
| **Example** | | |
| **Where is their sufficient reason found?** | | |

## Diagram: Leibniz's argument ◇

Slide 18 pictures a chain of contingent states with a sufficient reason outside it. Complete the diagram.

| State 1 (contingent) | State 2 (contingent) | State 3 (contingent) | State 4 … (contingent) |
|---|---|---|---|

▲

| The sufficient reason lies outside the series. It must be… |
|---|
| |

6.3 Explain the diagram in prose. Use steps 4, 6 and 7 of slide 17 to show why the sufficient reason must be necessary.

Part 07

# Objections: Hume and Russell

## Table: three problems with the cosmological argument ▦

| Problem (slide 11) | What it claims (own words) | Which step of which argument it attacks | Possible reply |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. The causal principle cannot be known analytically | | | |
| 2. An infinite regress is possible | | | |
| 3. A first cause need not be God | | | |

> *'...all distinct ideas are separable from each other, and as the ideas of cause and effect are evidently distinct, 'twill be easy for us to conceive an object to be non-existent this moment, and existent the next, without conjoining to it the idea of a cause or productive principle.'*
>
> — David Hume (as quoted on slide 13)

## Diagram: Hume on the causal principle ◇

| Cause and effect are distinct ideas | Distinct ideas are... |
|---|---|

▼

So we can conceive of...

▼

Therefore the causal principle cannot be known...

**7.1** If the causal principle is not known a priori, how does Hume think we come to believe it?

**7.2** Explain the 'infinity plus one' argument against an infinite regress (slide 14). Then explain why it does not rule out an infinite regress a priori.

## Russell and the fallacy of composition ✎✎

**7.3** What is the fallacy of composition? Use the pile of paper example.

**7.4** Explain how Aquinas and Leibniz could be accused of this fallacy.

**7.5** Using the wooden table example, explain how a defender might reply to Russell.

## Table: is a necessary being possible?

| | Hume and Russell's claim |
|---|---|
| The principle they rely on | |
| What we can imagine about God | |
| What follows about a 'necessary being' | |
| The only things that are necessary | |

## Part 08 Twelve-mark practice

These five questions are taken from the final slide. Each needs a clear, step-by-step explanation of the argument or objection. Use your diagrams and tables from this workbook to plan before you write.

### Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ Have I set out the argument(s) step by step, in a logical order?
- ☐ Is every sentence relevant to the exact question asked?
- ☐ Have I used the key terms precisely (necessary, contingent, sufficient reason, sustaining cause)?
- ☐ Have I explained each step, not just listed it?

**A** **Outline and explain the first cause argument for the existence of God.** [12 marks]

**B** **Outline and explain some objections to the first cause argument.** [12 marks]

**C** **Outline and explain Aquinas' Third Way.** [12 marks]

**D** **Outline and explain Leibniz's cosmological argument from sufficient reason.** [12 marks]

**E** **Outline and explain the objections to this from Hume and Russell.** [12 marks]